Chapter Eighty-One

The House of Visconti and the Papal States

Between 1368 and 1390,
the pope tries to return to Rome,
the Viscontis fight to claim the north of Italy,
and the papacy divides

Pope Urban V had returned to Rome, but a single year in the Eternal City had given him a deep appreciation for Avignon.

Italy was seething. South of the Papal States, the Kingdom of Naples was friendly to the pope, but torn by palace intrigues and an ongoing feud with Sicily. The Papal States themselves had been without a head for sixty-five years, ever since the papacy had removed itself to Avignon; the cities within the Papal States were ruling themselves. Control of Rome itself had seesawed violently between Senate and various competing aristocratic families. In the north, the Lombard cities had reverted to their old independent ways, with little interference from the Holy Roman Emperor Charles IV. Charles was far more interested in Germany than in the old *regnum Italicum* of the empire; when he had gone to Rome for his own coronation, he had arrived in the morning, been crowned, and then left without even spending the night in the city.[1]

In this vacuum, the House of Visconti had expanded.

The Visconti family had begun its rise to power in Milan seven decades